

WEEK 8 · SOCIAL REPRODUCTION

CLASS 1

What Counts as Labor?

READING 1

Wages for School Work – Power of Women Collective

READING 2

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Childhood In and Through Social Reproduction Theory – Rosen

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POWER_♀ of WOMEN_♀

15p

Nursing Asian Women & Imperial Typewriters
Wages for Schoolwork Belfast
From Family Allowance to Wages for Housework



WAGES FOR SCHOOL WORK

Below is a conversation with Gaye and Karen, two students from a mixed comprehensive in South London.

POW: We understand that you've been circulating a petition on wages for schoolwork. What gave you the idea?

GAYE: Well at school. Our teacher wrote an article for a magazine telling people that there should be wages for school-children and he gave us one to read, and we thought it was a good idea.

POW: Did you then just discuss it among yourselves?

KAREN: No. First of all we was talking about it to the whole class. And then me and Gaye, we set up petitions, and we asked people if they agreed that we should get a wage to sign a piece of paper, and it has on it: 'This is a petition for a wage for schoolchildren', and anyone who agreed would sign. And we went all round our school. For one lesson we spoke to a class, and we had a discussion with that class about school wages and did they agree. And they were asking us where would the money come from, questions like this.

POW: Did the teachers just let you walk in like that?

KAREN: We had to be careful. Like some teachers don't agree and they would have chucked us out of the class. So we asked each teacher first did they agree. And if they said yes, we said, well can we see your class? And they said yes. But if they didn't agree, we just passed them by. Most of the teachers said yes. It was only a few that said no.

POW: The first time you all went to a first year class to speak were you scared?

BOTH: Yeah.

KAREN: We were careful not to put them off it but not to give them false facts. We had to tell them what we thought. Like we said, school-leaving age has gone up. If it never, you could be out earning a wage. Or if you didn't go to work, you couldn't get a job, you'd still be getting money off the State, wouldn't you, like the dole. So you're staying at school and you're not getting paid. And if you was a fifth year, what was your idea, would you like to get paid for coming to school? And they said, yeah.

POW: What did they say was wrong with the idea?

GAYE: Where is the money coming from was the main one. KAREN: And would the government tax their parents more. And we weren't really sure but we said we thought like Ford, the one who makes a lot of profit, like the rich people, they would get taxed more.

POW: Was the teacher there during this discussion?

KAREN: Yes. He was asking us questions, asking them questions, asking them to ask us questions, like involving us all. And like one child said, why not pay our parents that wage? But then the government would tax them, whereas the government can't tax us.

GAYE: And like, if we was naughty, they'd say, oh you're not getting your money today, and all things like these. Like if we had our own wage, we'd be independent.

POW: So how did you feel after this first session?

GAYE: Great.

KAREN: Yeah, you know, we thought, we put our feelings over and now we're getting moving. It's not just like our own opinions. Lots of people do agree and lots of people are prepared to come on strike or a demonstration, you know.

POW: Did you discuss that in the classroom, about strike or demonstration?

GAYE: We didn't say it was a strike. We said, it isn't just for skipping school or just for laughs; it's for those people who believe in what we're doing.

KAREN: It's not for kids who want to have a half-day off or something, just to go home and have a muck-about or just a lark. It's got to be dead serious. If they believe in it, then the

best thing is to stay at school.

POW: So then you went to other classes. What did they ask you?

GAYE: The pupils in the first year, they said, how much do we get paid?

KAREN: 'We want £10 a day' or something like that. But we said we don't know.

GAYE: Fifty pence a day to start off, and we thought, when the fifth and sixth years get it, then the fourth years will go on strike and they'll want it. And gradually it'll go all through the school. And they'll all want it in the end. And then they'll go on strike for more money when things go up.

POW: What did you tell people about signing the petition?

KAREN: Like we discussed the school wage matter, and we said, if you agree with it, sign the paper. But we said we won't show this paper to anyone so it won't like get you into trouble. And we said, we're going to go on a demonstration soon; would you be prepared to come? And most of them said, they would. And we said, you don't have to come; we're not pushing you to come, but it would be a good thing if you'd come and support us. And they said they would.

GAYE: The people that didn't want to come and support us, we got their names on another piece of paper.

POW: They were for the wage but they weren't for the demonstration?

KAREN: Yes.

GAYE: If we could get just a few people from all the schools in the south London area, and then one night we have a meeting and discuss when we're going out and then we'd print some pamphlets saying what day, and then we just distribute them all over the schools. And then on that piece of paper has the date that we're going on strike.

POW: What do your parents think about this?

KAREN: Well my dad said he agreed in some ways but he's not so sure because he thinks it'll come like he'll get taxed more and that. And my mum, she agrees except that she doesn't know where the money's coming from either.

GAYE: Well my mum agrees with it. She signed her name and she said that if we had the march she would even come along with us. And my dad agrees. My mum said she would take off work that day and so would my dad.

POW: Do you think that your parents, Karen, who are not so much in favour of it, would try to prevent you from going on your demonstration?

KAREN: No. My dad said if ever I agreed with anything I should do it. If I knew all the facts, the proper facts, you know, and if I really agreed with it, I should do it. Like there was a strike for the Brockwell Three and I went on that. And I told my mum and my dad and they said, well if I really did agree, then I should go on strike.

POW: One of the problems that we've had in explaining wages for housework is that sometimes people ask us the same questions they ask you about school wages. And sometimes we can't give them an answer. But it still doesn't change our minds.

What do you do when you can't answer?

KAREN: Well we've just set ourselves up. It's not an organisation or nothing like that, you know. And so I say, well we'll open the discussion soon, we'll raise that question, I say, because I've got no answer for that question just yet.

GAYE: On Friday we was gonna go out and interview people in the park, men and women, to ask them what they thought of it. But we broke up early and so we didn't get the chance. But with a bit of luck we'll do it this Friday.

KAREN: We can go round the streets with a tape recorder and just stop a passerby and say, we believe in a school wage, and we'll say why we believe this, and that. And if they agree, you know, ask them their views on it.

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(Continued from p.6)

GAYE: And if they don't, we'll still ask them their views on it and why they don't.

KAREN: We'll play it back in school and maybe it'll give us some rough ideas what to do.

POW: I noticed that you say 'wages for schoolchildren' sometimes. Are you a child?

KAREN: No. For school pupils.

GAYE: Because we put it this way. If you're on a bus if you're over 14 you have to pay full fare. If you're over 14 and go to the pictures you have to pay full to get in. Well how come if we can't go out earning a wage or if we're going to school and don't get no money for doing work in school, why should we have to pay full fare in the pictures to get in and on the buses and trains?

KAREN: I typed out a thing and on it I put 'students' or 'pupils'. I never put 'children'.

GAYE: You know, like our fifth year, they don't stay at school. Although the school-leaving age has gone up, they try and get a job somewhere where the people will take them because they want to get paid, they want to be independent.

KAREN: There's a girl in our fifth year, there was a cafe over the road, and she used to work in there.

POW: After school.

KAREN: No, in school hours. And teachers used to go over there and they used to see her and they didn't say nothing to her.

POW: But a lot of people don't go to school at all.

KAREN: They prefer to get some kind of a job to be paid. But if they knew they was going to get paid at school, then they'd come.

POW: But aren't there a lot of young people who don't go to school and don't go to a job that's paying either?

GAYE: I don't know. Like my mate, she goes over the Oval House and that's like a place where young people go and they have drama over there, of a night time and of a daytime sometimes. And there's a free school and once it's legalised sort of thing, she wants to go there. She prefers to go there, because you can go in when you want and you can have what lesson you want when you want it.

POW: What do you think is the difference in the need for a wage between women and men of your age?

GAYE: I've not actually thought of that question. The boys, they get paid more anyway. From their parents. If they get a job, right, they'd get paid more anyway. And also their parents always give them more because they are boys like. It's the natural thing, boys can stay out later than girls.

POW: It's not a natural thing.

GAYE: Well it may not be natural but that's what happens. My brother is younger than me. And his last birthday he was 12 and I'm near 15. I had a big argument with my mum because in the weekdays I've got to be in at 10 o'clock. And they said that my brother's got to be in at 10 o'clock too. And I made a big argument about it. It's not fair at all.

POW: What about the amount of money that a woman spends? I notice, Gaye, you have eye makeup, and I know it's expensive.

GAYE: It's not fair though, really, because men get paid more. Yet they don't have to pay out for the little things like we have to.

KAREN: They don't wear tights either.

POW: Are you going to raise this in your campaign?

KAREN: Well I don't know, really. This really isn't a fight against men; it's just for the wage for all of us. The main point is they're fifth years and they've had to stay on.

GAYE: But there again the boys work the same hours as us and do the same amount of work, and if they say boys should get 10 bob extra, and the teachers agree, we'll fight against it.

POW: How much housework do you do?

GAYE: I have to make me bed every morning and change the sheets on a Sunday and dust me own bedroom. And then we



Drawing by Alexis Wood

take turns: it's either me mum does the washing up teatime or me do the washing up and she does the wiping.

POW: And what does your brother do?

GAYE: Go in the living room and watch telly

POW: So it's all thrown on your mother.

KAREN: Yes, but there again, certain people say, what's a mum for? She's supposed to do the beds and the washing.

POW: Are you going to do it when you get married?

GAYE: If I have children, one does the washing up, one does the drying, one does the cleaning. But the point is that if my mum went in hospital my brother would know what's hit him, know what I mean?

POW: You're now fourth years. But you're fighting for a wage for when you're fifth years. Why not for all school students?

KAREN: Because in about the fourth or fifth year, you need more than what you really did in the third year and the second, because you really like more clothes if your mates have got clothes

POW: What do you have for spending money now?

GAYE: I got two jobs. I'm partly employed in a doctor's surgery some evenings for about a fiver a week. And then I work Friday night for the tenants' association selling tickets for blind children.

The government in the last ballot, they said that in September they're going to try and stop all jobs for children under 16. Like if you work in Woolworths, you've got to have a work permit. And that'll be more sort of towards a school wage, because they'll think, oh no, they've not got a job now, and they ain't got so much money, so what are we gonna do? POW: Your mum has a job outside the home and she has a bit of cash of her own. If she was a full-time housewife you would be in trouble, wouldn't you?

KAREN: Yeah. But I don't get a lot of money, you know. I only get however much I need to go out, like a couple of bob a night. But my mum can't always do this. Sometimes she say 'You know, money don't grow on trees', and 'I only got a part-time job, you can't expect me to give you this, go and scrounge off your dad,' something like that.

GAYE: Yes, but if your dad only went to work it would have been worse still, because you only get that much money because they're both at work.

KAREN: Yes. And they give me the money because I need it. I'm not old enough so I can't get a wage from a job. So really, you know, it would be good if I had a school wage. It would make me more independent instead of having to say, oh mum, can I have some money, or dad, can I have some money?

EXAMINATION BOOK

Name _____

Subject _____

Class _____ Section _____

Instructor _____ Date _____

wages for students

THE MENTAL DISCIPLINE FACTORY IN 1965

"IT IS MORNING. THE WEATHERMAN DECLARES DAYLIGHT AND PLACES THE SUN (RAIN, SNOW, CLOUDS, ETC, WHICHEVER IS MOST APPROPRIATE) IN THE SKY. AND LIKE MECHANIZED CLOCK-TIME, THE EARTH TICK-TOCKS AROUND THE SUN AGAIN."

JOHN DOE BELONGS TO UNIT 12 OF THE ELM CITY MENTAL DISCIPLINE FACTORY. HE IS OUR EXAMPLE FOR THE DAY. JOHN IS AVERAGE OR WAS UNTIL HE WENT WRONG. HE WAS SITTING IN OUR PHYSICAL-NEED ROOM WITH HIS FELLOW MASS-PRODUCTIONS, PENCIL IN RIGHT HAND, PAPER ON TABLE, MIND ON HIS OWN WORK, BUSY.

BY THE WAY, FOR SOME BACKGROUND INFORMATION. THE ORIGINAL EXCUSE FOR OUR PHYSICAL-NEED ROOM'S EXISTENCE WAS FOR "PRODUCING AND DISTRIBUTING FOOD TO SUPPLEMENT OUR DISCIPLINARY TEACHINGS WITH PHYSICAL ENCOURAGEMENT AND SEMI-SATISFACTION." BUT ITS PURPOSE NOW IS A GATHERING PLACE FOR JOHN DOES WHO AREN'T SCHEDULED FOR ANYTHING MORE IMPORTANT. HERE WE TEACH THEM OBEDIENCE, A VERY VERY, VERY IMPORTANT PART OF OVERALL MENTAL DISCIPLINE.

BUT ABOUT JOHN DOE. HE WAS ALRIGHT UNTIL HE DEVELOPED THE AUDACITY TO GET UP AND GO RIGHT OVER TO OUR WATER FOUNTAIN AND DRINK 2 HUGE GULPS OF WATER, COMPLETELY FILLING HIS MOUTH AND QUENCHING HIS THIRST AT OUR EXPENSE.

NOW, YOU'VE ALL BEEN DISCIPLINED TO REALIZE THAT IS NOT THE PURPOSE OF OUR WATER FOUNTAINS. YOU'VE BEEN PROGRAMMED TO UNDERSTAND THEY'RE FOR DISCIPLINARY TEMPTATION AND HAVE A PART IN OUR PLAN ONLY FOR THAT PURPOSE. YOU HAVE TO MASTER YOUR THIRST, NOT LIKE JOHN. HE IS BAD, BAD, BAD, BAD. ONE OF OUR SUPERVISORS HAD TO HAVE HIM ESCORTED TO THE MEDICAL SURGEON WHO PROMPTLY SEWED HIS LIPS TOGETHER.

SOME OF US THINK JOHN'S PUNISHMENT WAS TOO SLIGHT FOR SUCH A DISGRACEFUL SHOW OF DISOBEDIENCE. BUT WE DO STILL BELIEVE IN MERCY. PRINCIPLE IS PRINCIPLE BUT WHAT IS PRINCIPLE WORTH IF HUMANITY IS IGNORED.

STUDY SIGNIFICANCE FOR LECTURE TOMORROW.

(WRITTEN IN SCHOOL BY A HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT)

WHAT IS SCHOOLWORK?

GOING TO SCHOOL, BEING A STUDENT IS WORK. THIS WORK IS CALLED SCHOOLWORK ALTHOUGH IT IS NOT USUALLY CONSIDERED TO REALLY BE WORK SINCE WE DON'T RECEIVE ANY WAGES FOR DOING IT. THIS DOES NOT MEAN THAT SCHOOLWORK IS NOT WORK, BUT RATHER THAT THEY HAVE TAUGHT US TO BELIEVE THAT ONLY IF YOU ARE PAID DO YOU REALLY WORK.

SCHOOLWORK TAKES THE FORM OF MANY DIFFERENT TASKS OF VARYING INTENSITIES AND COMBINATIONS OF SKILLED AND UNSKILLED LABOR. FOR EXAMPLE, WE ARE TO LEARN TO SIT QUIETLY IN CLASSROOMS FOR LONG PERIODS OF TIME AND NOT CAUSE A DISTURBANCE. WE ARE TO LISTEN ATTENTIVELY AND ATTEMPT TO MEMORIZE WHAT IS BEING SAID. WE ARE TO BE OBEDIENT TO TEACHERS. OCCASIONALLY WE LEARN CERTAIN TECHNICAL SKILLS THAT MAKE US MORE PRODUCTIVE WHEN WE WORK IN JOBS OUTSIDE OF SCHOOL THAT REQUIRE THESE SKILLS. MOST OF THE TIME, HOWEVER, WE SPEND DOING A LOT OF UNSKILLED LABOR.

THE CHARACTERISTIC COMMON TO ALL THE SPECIFIC TASKS THAT SCHOOLWORK INVOLVES IS DISCIPLINE, I.E. FORCED WORK. SOMETIMES WE ARE DISCIPLINED WHICH MEANS THAT WE ARE FORCED TO WORK BY OTHERS (TEACHERS, PRINCIPALS, AND GUARDS). AT OTHER TIMES WE ARE SELF-DISCIPLINED WHICH MEANS THAT WE FORCE OURSELVES TO DO SCHOOLWORK. NOT SURPRISINGLY, THE DIFFERENT CATEGORIES OF SCHOOLWORK USED TO BE CALLED DISCIPLINES.

OBVIOUSLY, IT IS CHEAPER AND BETTER FOR CAPITAL IF WE DO

OUR OWN DISCIPLINING. THIS SAVES PAYING FOR MORE TEACHERS, PRINCIPALS, AND GUARDS WHO ARE WAGED WORKERS AND HAVE TO BE PAID SOMETHING. AS SELF-DISCIPLINED STUDENTS, WE PERFORM THE DOUBLE TASK OF DOING SCHOOLWORK AND MAKING OURSELVES DO IT. THAT IS WHY SCHOOL ADMINISTRATORS PLACE SO MUCH EMPHASIS ON THE SELF-DISCIPLINARY ASPECTS OF SCHOOL WHILE TRYING TO KEEP THE COSTS OF DISCIPLINING US TO A MINIMUM.

LIKE ALL CAPITALISTIC INSTITUTIONS, SCHOOLS ARE FACTORIES. GRADING AND TRACKING ARE WAYS OF MEASURING OUR PRODUCTIVITY WITHIN THE SCHOOL-FACTORY. NOT ONLY ARE WE TRAINED TO TAKE OUR FUTURE "POSITION IN SOCIETY" BUT WE ARE ALSO BEING PROGRAMMED TO GO TO OUR "PROPER PLACE". THE SCHOOL-FACTORY IS AN ESSENTIAL STEP IN THE SELECTION PROCESS THAT WILL SEND SOME TO SWEEP THE STREETS AND SOME TO SUPERVISE THE SWEEPERS.

SCHOOLWORK MAY ALSO INCLUDE SOME LEARNING THAT THE STUDENTS THEMSELVES FIND USEFUL. THIS ASPECT, HOWEVER, IS RIGIDLY SUBORDINATED TO CAPITAL'S MOST IMMEDIATE SELF-INTEREST: WORKING-CLASS DISCIPLINE. AFTER ALL, WHAT GOOD TO CAPITAL IS AN ENGINEER WHO SPEAKS CHINESE AND CAN SOLVE DIFFERENTIAL EQUATIONS IF HE NEVER SHOWS UP FOR WORK?

WHY SCHOOLWORK?

MOST ECONOMISTS AGREE: "SCHOOLWORK IS BOTH A CONSUMPTION AND INVESTMENT GOOD." SO THEIR ANSWER TO THE QUESTION OF WHY SCHOOLWORK IS THAT THE SCHOOLING YOU GET HAS THIS MARVELOUS TWO-SIDED GOOD ABOUT IT. NOT ONLY DO YOU INVEST IN YOURSELF IN SUCH A WAY THAT YOU CAN EXPECT TO GET A HIGH PAYING JOB IN THE FUTURE BUT ALSO IT IS FUN! THIS IS A FAR CRY FROM THE DAYS WHEN INVESTMENT WAS ABSTENTION, BUT CAN WE TAKE THIS STUFF SERIOUSLY?

LET US CONSIDER THE "CONSUMPTION" SIDE. SINCE BY CONSUMPTION GOOD THE ECONOMISTS MEAN SOMETHING THAT IS ENJOYABLE, PLEASURABLE, AND SATISFYING, THEN ANYONE CALLING SCHOOLING A CONSUMPTION GOOD MUST BE KIDDING. THE CONSTANT PRESSURE TO FINISH ASSIGNMENTS, THE HASSLE OF SCHEDULES, THE STUPID SLEEPLESS NIGHTS TO STUDY FOR EXAMS, AND THE REST OF THE SELF-DISCIPLINING THAT GOES ON IMMEDIATELY QUELLS ANY POSSIBLE FUN. IT IS LIKE SAYING THAT GOING TO PRISON IS A CONSUMPTION GOOD BECAUSE IT IS A PLEASURE TO GET OUT!

SURELY ONE MIGHT SAY THAT THERE IS SOME ENJOYMENT GOING ON IN SCHOOL, BUT IT ISN'T THE EDUCATION. RATHER, IT IS THE STRUGGLE AGAINST THAT EDUCATION THAT'S ENJOYABLE. IT IS THE TRIPS YOU TAKE TO GET AWAY FROM CLASSES, THE LOVE AFFAIRS THAT ARE SO DISTRACTING, THE MEANDERING CONVERSATIONS IN BARS, THE DEMONSTRATIONS THAT SHUT IT DOWN, THE WRONG BOOKS READ AND THE RIGHT BOOKS READ

AT THE WRONG TIME: ALL THAT YOU DO NOT TO BE EDUCATED. SO ON THE CONSUMPTION SIDE, THE CONCLUSION IS EXACTLY THE OPPOSITE OF THE ECONOMISTS.

WHAT ABOUT THE "INVESTMENT" SIDE? ALL THROUGHOUT THE SIXTIES ECONOMICS PROFESSORS, BANKERS, "GUIDANCE" COUNSELORS AGREED: SCHOOL WAS A GOOD PERSONAL INVESTMENT. THE IDEA WAS THAT YOU SHOULD TREAT YOURSELF LIKE A LITTLE CORPORATION, A MINI-GM, SO THAT YOU COULD INVEST IN YOURSELF BY GOING TO SCHOOL IN THE SAME WAY A CORPORATION BUYS MACHINES IN ORDER TO MAKE A BIGGER PROFIT OPERATING ON THE PRINCIPLE: YOU HAVE TO SPEND MONEY (INVEST) IN ORDER TO MAKE MONEY. IF YOU COULD RAISE THE MONEY (AND THE STOMACH) TO GO TO SCHOOL EITHER BY GETTING A LOAN, OR WORKING A SECOND JOB, OR GETTING YOUR PARENTS TO PAY, YOU COULD EXPECT TO MAKE A PROFIT ON THAT MONEY BECAUSE YOU COULD EXPECT TO GET A HIGHER PAYING JOB IN THE FUTURE DUE TO YOUR INCREASED SCHOOLING. IN THE HEYDAY OF WHAT THEY CALLED "THE HUMAN CAPITAL REVOLUTION", LEARNED ECONOMISTS FIGURED THAT YOU WOULD GET A BETTER RETURN IN INVESTING IN YOUR EDUCATION THAN IF YOU BOUGHT GM STOCK. THIS WAS CAPITALISM FOR THE WORKING CLASS WITH A VENGEANCE!

ASIDE FROM THE DISTASTE THAT THIS "INVESTMENT VIEW" MIGHT CAUSE – FOR IF YOU ARE A CORPORATION THEN ONE PART OF YOU IS GOING TO BE A WORKER AND ANOTHER PART OF YOU IS GOING TO BE THE BOSS OVER THAT WORKER – ONE MIGHT WONDER WHETHER

YOU ACTUALLY GET MORE MONEY FROM GOING TO SCHOOL IN THE LONG RUN. IN THE SIXTIES EVERYONE ASSURED YOU THAT YOU WOULD, BUT IN THE "CRISIS-RIDDEN" SEVENTIES ALL BETS ARE OFF. THE AUTHORITIES ARE NOW SAYING THAT THEIR PREVIOUS ANALYSES WERE ALL MISCONCEIVED, THAT YOU CANNOT EXPECT ANY SUCH "GOOD RETURN" TO YOUR INVESTMENT IN YOURSELF. NOT SURPRISINGLY IT NOW TURNS OUT THAT YOU ARE NOT A BETTER PROFIT MAKING OPERATION THAN GM. AT BEST ALL THEY CAN COME UP WITH IS A POSSIBLE INCREASE IN WHAT THEY CALLED YOUR "PSYCHIC" INCOME, IN THAT IF YOU GET MORE SCHOOLING YOU MIGHT LAND A "NICER" IF NOT A HIGHER PAYING JOB; BUT EVEN THIS IS NOT GUARANTEED, ESPECIALLY SINCE ALL THE "NICE", "CLEAN" JOBS ARE BECOMING UNCERTAIN, HARDER TO DO, AND EVEN DANGEROUS, E.G. TEACHING. IT SEEMS THAT STUDENTS HAVE BEEN MISPLANNED.

IT IS OBVIOUS TO EVERY STUDENT THAT THIS "INVESTMENT GOOD" ATTEMPT TO MAKE YOU SEE THE WISDOM OF WORKING FOR FREE OR EVEN PAYING TO WORK IN SCHOOL IS A PHONEY. SO IT IS GETTING HARDER AND HARDER TO CONVINCE ANYONE TO SHELL OUT MONEY FOR SCHOOLING ON THE BASIS OF THE FAIRY TALE OF YOU AS PROFIT MAKING CORPORATION. SO NOW BOTH SIDES OF THE ECONOMISTS' CLAIM COLLAPSE, BUT IN THE MIDST OF THIS DEBACLE SCHOOLWORK GETS A NEW DEFENDER FROM WHAT MIGHT SEEM TO BE A SURPRISING QUARTER: THE LEFT.

THE "SOCIALIST" TEACHER AND THE "REVOLUTIONARY" STUDENT HAVE BECOME THE STAUCHEST DEFENDERS OF THE PUBLIC UNIVERSITY AGAINST "BUDGET CUT-BACKS" AND THE LIKE. WHY? THEIR STORY

GOES SOMETHING LIKE THIS: EDUCATION LEADS TO THE ABILITY TO MAKE MORE AND BROADER CONNECTIONS IN YOUR SOCIAL SITUATION, IN A WORD, EDUCATION MAKES YOU MORE CONSCIOUS. SINCE THE PUBLIC UNIVERSITIES OPEN UP THE POSSIBILITY OF HAVING A HIGHLY EDUCATED WORKING CLASS, THESE UNIVERSITIES MAKE IT POSSIBLE FOR THE WORKING CLASS TO BECOME MORE CLASS CONSCIOUS; FURTHER, A MORE CONSCIOUS WORKING CLASS WILL PAY LESS ATTENTION TO THE MERELY "ECONOMISTIC" DEMANDS FOR MORE MONEY AND LESS WORK, AND PAY MORE ATTENTION TO THE POLITICAL TASK OF "BUILDING SOCIALISM". THIS LOGIC GIVES THE LEFT BOTH AN EXPLANATION OF THE UNIVERSITY CRISIS – CAPITAL IS AFRAID OF THE HIGHLY CONSCIOUS WORKING CLASS THAT THE UNIVERSITY WAS BEGINNING TO SPAWN – AND A DEMAND – MORE SCHOOLWORK AND NOT LESS! SO IN THE NAME OF POLITICAL CONSCIOUSNESS AND SOCIALISM THESE LEFTISTS INTENSIFY SCHOOLWORK (WHICH IS JUST WAGELESS WORK) AND FROWN UPON STUDENT DEMANDS FOR LESS OF IT AS CAPITALISTIC BACKSLIDING. AT A TIME WHEN ALL THE USUAL DEFENSES OF THE FREE WORK DONE AT SCHOOLS ARE BEING EXPOSED, THE LEFT NOW SEIZES THE TIME AS ITS CHANCE TO LEAD THE WORKING CLASS OUT OF ITS "MATERIALISTIC" SLEEP TO ITS HIGHER MISSION: THE MAKING OF A SOCIALISTIC SOCIETY.

BUT THE LEFT RUNS AFOUL OF THAT OLD QUESTION POSED TO PREVIOUS ENLIGHTENERS OF THE WORKING CLASS: WHO SHALL EDUCATE THE EDUCATORS? SINCE THE LEFT DOES NOT START FROM THE OBVIOUS: SCHOOLWORK IS UNWAGED WORK, ALL ITS EFFORTS LEAD TO MORE UNWAGED WORK FOR CAPITAL, TO MORE EXPLOITATION. ALL ITS ATTEMPTS TO

INCREASE CLASS CONSCIOUSNESS REMAIN OBLIVIOUS TO CAPITAL'S CONTROL ON ITS OWN GROUND AND SO THE LEFT ENDS IN CONSISTENTLY SUPPORTING CAPITAL'S EFFORTS TO INTENSIFY WORK, IN RATIONALIZING AND DISCIPLINING THE WORKING CLASS. SO THE "BUILDING OF SOCIALISM" BECOMES JUST ANOTHER DEVICE FOR GETTING MORE FREE WORK IN THE SERVICE OF CAPITAL.

SO CAPITAL'S AND THE LEFT'S DEFENSE OF THE WAGELESS CHARACTER OF SCHOOLWORK JUST FALLS ON ITS FACE.

STUDENTS ARE UNPAID WORKERS

STUDENTS BELONG TO THE WORKING CLASS. MORE SPECIFICALLY, WE BELONG TO THAT PART OF THE WORKING CLASS THAT IS UNWAGED (UNPAID). OUR WAGELESSNESS CONDEMNS US TO LIVES OF POVERTY, DEPENDENCE, AND OVERWORK. BUT WORST OF ALL, NOT GETTING A WAGE MEANS THAT WE LACK THE POWER THAT THE WAGE PROVIDES IN DEALING WITH CAPITAL.

WITHOUT THE WAGE WE ARE CONDEMNED TO LIVES OF BARE EXISTENCE. WE ARE FORCED TO SURVIVE ON WHAT OTHERS WOULDN'T TOLERATE. THE HOUSING WE CAN AFFORD TO RENT IS SUBSTANDARD AND OVERCROWDED. THE FOOD WE EAT, MUST EAT, IS CHEAP INSTITUTIONAL FOOD OF THE CHEAPEST BRANDS. OUR CLOTHING AND ENTERTAINMENT ARE STANDARDIZED AND DRAB. WE ARE A CLEAR CASE OF POVERTY.

SINCE WE ARE MOSTLY UNWAGED AND SINCE WE DO HAVE TO LIVE, WE HAVE TO GET THE MONEY FROM SOMEWHERE ELSE, BY BEING DEPENDENT ON SOMEONE WHO DOES RECEIVE A WAGE. FOR SOME STUDENTS, SUBSISTENCE AND TUITION ARE AT LEAST PARTIALLY TAKEN CARE OF BY A DEAR RELATIVE. AS UNWAGED STUDENTS, HOWEVER, WE ARE IN A RELATIONSHIP OF DEPENDENCE UPON OUR PARENTS OR OTHER BENEFACTORS THAT LEAVES US POWERLESS. FURTHER, IF A WHOLE FAMILY SACRIFICES – THE MOTHER GETS A SECOND JOB AND THE FATHER SWEATS TO PAY FOR OUR SCHOOLING, OUR PARENTS ARE WEAKENED IN THEIR STRUGGLE AGAINST WORK WHILE WE ARE BLACKMAILED INTO ACCEPTING THE SCHOOL WORK. EVEN THOUGH WE DO AS MUCH WORK AS THE WAGED, WE ARE MADE

TO BE DEPENDENT UPON THEM; FOR WITH THE EXCEPTION OF THOSE STUDENTS WHO DO RECEIVE WAGES (IN THE ARMED FORCES, IN THE "ENLIGHTENED" LOMPOC JAIL IN CALIFORNIA, IN PRIVATE CORPORATION TRAINING PROGRAMS, IN MANPOWER TRAINING) MOST STUDENTS GET NO WAGE AT ALL FOR THE SCHOOLWORK THEY DO.

FOR THOSE OF US WHO DO NOT RECEIVE SUCH SUPPORT, NOT GETTING A WAGE MEANS HAVING TO WORK AN ADDITIONAL JOB OUTSIDE OF SCHOOL. AND SINCE THE LABOR MARKET IS SATURATED WITH STUDENTS LOOKING FOR THESE JOBS, CAPITAL IMPOSES MINIMUM WAGES AND BENEFITS ON US. AS A RESULT, WE WORK EVEN MORE HOURS OR EVEN ADDITIONAL JOBS. SINCE OUR SCHOOLWORK IS UNPAID, MOST OF US WORK DURING THE SO-CALLED SUMMER VACATION. EVEN IF WE TAKE THE TIME OFF WE HAVE NO MONEY WITH WHICH TO ENJOY IT. THE ABSURDITY OF THIS IS EVEN FURTHER MAGNIFIED BY THE VERY HIGH PRODUCTIVITY REQUIREMENTS WHICH ARE CONSTANTLY BEING IMPOSED ON US AS STUDENTS (EXAMS, QUIZZES, PAPERS, ETC.) AND BY THE WAY WE ARE BEING PROGRAMMED SO THAT WE IMPOSE FURTHER PRODUCTIVITY REQUIREMENTS ON OURSELVES (EXTRA CREDIT WORK, OUTSIDE READING AND THINKING FOR OUR CLASSES - NOT FOR OURSELVES, ON-THE-JOB TRAINING, STUDENT TEACHING, ETC.) ON THE ONE HAND WE ARE FORCED TO WORK FOR NOTHING AND ON THE OTHER, WE ARE FORCED TO WORK FOR ALMOST NOTHING.

OF COURSE, WE ARE TOLD THAT IT WILL ALL BE MADE UP TO US IN THE FUTURE. THEY SAY THAT WE WILL BE GIVEN THIS MEANINGFUL, HIGH-PAYING JOB WITH A SECRETARY. OUR FREE WORK WILL NOT BE IN

VAIN. BUT, AS WE KNOW EVEN BEFORE WE JOYFULLY DANCE OUT OF THIS FACTORY, THERE IS NOTHING TO LOOK FORWARD TO BUT A VERY DEPRESSING JOB AS HOTEL CLERK IN THE LOCAL HOLIDAY INN, OR, AT BEST, AS A SECRETARY AT OUR OLD WORKPLACE WITHIN THE UNIVERSITY.

THE REALITY OF THE SITUATION IS ONE IN WHICH TODAY STUDENTS ARE ALREADY STARTING TO GET PAID FOR SCHOOLWORK:

- ARMED FORCES - THE ROTC PAYS \$100 A MONTH PLUS TUITION FOR STUDYING
- SOME CORPORATIONS PAY THEIR EMPLOYEES TO ATTEND NIGHT SCHOOL OR CONTINUE STUDYING TOWARDS ADVANCED DEGREES.
- JAILERS AT THE LOMPOC JAIL ARE PAYING SOME OF THEIR PRISONERS TO DO SCHOOLWORK AT THE UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA.
- MANPOWER TRAINING CLIENTS RECEIVE STIPENDS WHILE TRAINING.
- SOCIAL SECURITY BENEFITS
- SCHOLARSHIP RECIPIENTS (BEOG)
- VIETNAM ERA VETERANS

FOR MORE INFORMATION AND PAMPHLETS WRITE TO :

WFS
215 ALPS ROAD
BRANFORD, CONN.
USA

104 STATE ST.
NORTHAMPTON, MASS. 01060



WAGES FOR STUDENTS

WE ARE FED UP WITH WORKING FOR FREE
WE DEMAND REAL MONEY NOW FOR THE SCHOOLWORK WE DO.

WE MUST FORCE CAPITAL, WHICH PROFITS FROM OUR WORK, TO PAY FOR OUR SCHOOLWORK. ONLY THEN CAN WE STOP DEPENDING ON FINANCIAL AID, OUR PARENTS, WORKING SECOND AND THIRD JOBS OR WORKING DURING SUMMER VACATIONS FOR OUR EXISTENCE. WE ALREADY EARN A WAGE; NOW WE MUST BE PAID IT. ONLY IN THIS WAY CAN WE SEIZE MORE POWER TO USE IN OUR DEALINGS WITH CAPITAL.

WE CAN DO A LOT WITH THE MONEY. FIRST, WE WILL HAVE TO WORK LESS AS THE "NEED TO WORK" ADDITIONAL JOBS DISAPPEARS. SECOND, WE WILL IMMEDIATELY ENJOY A HIGHER STANDARD OF LIVING SINCE WE WILL HAVE MORE TO SPEND WHEN WE TAKE TIME OFF FROM SCHOOLWORK. THIRD, WE WILL RAISE THE AVERAGE WAGE IN THE ENTIRE AREA AFFECTED BY THE PRESENCE OF US LOW-COST WORKERS.

BY TAKING TIME OFF FROM SCHOOLWORK TO DEMAND WAGES FOR STUDENTS, WE THINK AND ACT AGAINST THE WORK WE ARE DOING. IT ALSO PUTS US IN A BETTER POSITION TO GET THE MONEY.

NO MORE UNPAID SCHOOLWORK!

THE WAGES FOR STUDENTS STUDENTS

HARPER'S MAGAZINE

NOVEMBER 2017

[Readings]

The Working Classroom

by Malcolm Harris

From Kids These Days, a book about millennials published this month by Little, Brown.

In April 2014, the Harley Avenue Primary School in Elwood, New York, sent a letter to the parents of its kindergartners, confirming rumors that the school would not be going ahead with its annual play.

Dear Kindergarten Parents and Guardians,

We hope this letter serves to help you better understand how the demands of the twenty-first century are changing schools.

The reason for eliminating the kindergarten show is simple. We are responsible for preparing children for college and careers with valuable lifelong skills and know that we can best do that by having them become strong readers, writers, coworkers, and problem solvers. Please do not fault us for making professional decisions that we know will never please everyone. But know that we are making these decisions with the interests of all children in mind.

These kids, the letter implied, could not spare two days from their regularly scheduled work.

What we teach and how we teach it is changing to meet the demands of a changing world, wrote the administrators at Harley Avenue. But what are the changes, exactly?

The main thing is that twenty-first-century American kids are required to work more than their predecessors. This generation is raised on problem-solving to the exclusion of play. Authorities from the Brookings Institution to *Time* magazine have called for an end to summer vacation and the imposition of year-round compulsory schooling. But the possible downsides of this trade-off are almost never discussed.

Parents, teachers, policymakers, and employers are all so worried that children won't "meet the demands of a changing world" that they don't bother asking what kids are expected to do to meet those demands, and what problems they're being equipped to solve. The anxious frenzy that surrounds the future has come to function as an excuse for the choices adults make for kids.

In America, unlike in much of the world, kids do not perform work. In this country, "child labor" evokes British industrialism, coal, and Dickens. And though some American children have always worked — especially on farms — the dominant U.S. view of childhood is that it is a time free from labor.

But it takes a lot of work to prepare yourself to compete for twenty-first-century employment. Adults are happy to remind kids of this, telling them, "Put your nose to the grindstone," "Stay on the right path," "Treat school like your job." When it comes to the right to organize, the dignity of labor, or minimum-wage laws, however, students are forced to be students rather than workers. It's a precarious position: America can no more afford to recognize children's work than it can afford for them not to do it. Meanwhile, disregarded and unregulated, the intensity and duration of this work have grown out of control.

Danny Dunn and the Homework Machine, a children's book from 1958, illustrates how learning is used to hide labor. Danny is a whiz kid always

seeking ways to cheat on his homework; he has a habit of dragging his friend Joe into his half-baked schemes. Danny sets up two pens linked by a board attached to pulleys and a weight so that he can do his and Joe's math homework at the same time. He laments, "If only we could save even more time. You'd think six hours of school would be enough for them, without making us take school home."

Danny and his friends use a computer belonging to their absentminded science teacher to do their homework quickly, leaving more time for baseball and other hobbies. These kids aren't slackers; they just have better things to do with their time than homework. When a jealous classmate rats out the crew, Danny has to explain to their teacher, Miss Arnold, what they've been doing. Rather than concede that he's been cheating, Danny argues that all workers use tools to do tasks better and faster, and that he and his fellow students should not be prevented from doing the same.

Even though it's a children's book, *Danny Dunn* depicts one of the major conflicts of the second half of the twentieth century: whether labor-saving technology benefits workers or owners. Will the computer lead to the kids working less or working more? With the help of Danny's mother, Miss Arnold develops a plan — the same plan, in essence, that would determine the character of American childhood half a century after the book appeared: she increases Danny's workload.

Technologies that make work faster function in one of two ways: by reducing the time spent on the work or by intensifying the nature of the work. It's not hard to see which way it has gone in America. The story of the homework machine is a parable for how schoolwork has followed the same trend toward intensification as other forms of labor. The only compensation Danny gets for his effort and accomplishment is a sticker — a nontransferable award. On the micro level, this looks like one educator's clever effort to trick a student into learning more than he meant to. But Danny is not an outlier. American kids now find themselves in his situ-

ation: overworked, underengaged, gold-starred, and tired, wondering where their time went.

When it comes to primary and secondary schooling, American adults are able to hold a few conflicting stereotypes in their minds at the same time. On the one hand, it's generally acknowledged that students, facing stiffer competition for college admissions, are doing historically anomalous amounts of homework. Between 1981 and 1997, elementary schoolers between the ages of six and eight saw a 146 percent increase in time spent studying. Kids aged nine to twelve sustained a nearly 30 percent increase in homework, while their time in class increased by 14 percent.

On the other, students are depicted as slackers who are unable to pay attention, or entitled brats who need to be congratulated for every routine accomplishment, or devolved cretins who can't form a full sentence without lapsing into textspeak.

The labor of classically employed workers is measured in both total output and wages, but we don't measure a student's educational product except in arbitrary and comparative ways, such as grades, standardized tests, and school awards. Nevertheless, I feel justified in saying that American children's educational output has grown steeply over the past thirty years. But what does educational output even mean, and how might we try to measure it? Where does the product go?

Waged workers receive money to mark their expended effort — even though it represents only a fraction of their total output. The student equivalent is the grade: we say a student has “worked for” or “earned” her marks; the return of graded papers or report cards resembles the distribution of paychecks. The system aspires to train every student for grade-A work, then calls it a crisis when the distribution shifts in that direction.

The idea that underlies contemporary schooling is that grades, eventually, turn into money, or, if not money, then choice, or what social scientists sometimes call better life outcomes. In waged work we have

the concept of valorization, which is the process by which laborers produce value above and beyond their wages and increase the mass of invested capital. But if no one is profiting off kids' scholastic work — teachers definitely don't — where does their product go? The sociologist Jürgen Zinnecker describes "the development of human capital" as a sink for students' hidden labor. In the simplest terms, this is what the kindergarten administrators at Harley Avenue Primary School stated in their letter: when students are working, what they're working on is their ability to work.

In 2013, an article appeared in *The Atlantic* with the title, "My Daughter's Homework Is Killing Me." The writer, Karl Taro Greenfeld, had attempted to complete the homework of his daughter, an eighth grader at a selective New York public school, to discover the exact nature of the labor that was keeping her up every night. He quickly found that he wasn't prepared to keep up:

Imagine if after putting in a full day at the office — and school is pretty much what our children do for a job — you had to come home and do another four or so hours of office work. . . . If your job required that kind of work after work, how long would you last?

This sort of intensive training isn't just for the children of intellectuals; the theory behind the rhetoric advocating universal college attendance is that any and all kids should aspire to this level of work. College admissions have become the focus not only of secondary schooling but of contemporary American childhood writ large. The sad truth, however, is that college admissions are designed to funnel young adults onto different tracks, not to validate hard work. A jump in the number of Harvard-caliber students doesn't have a corresponding effect on the size of the school's freshman class. Instead, it allows the university to become even more selective and to raise prices, to stock up on geniuses and rich kids. This is the central problem with an education system designed to create

the most human capital possible: an increase in ability within a competitive system doesn't advantage all individuals.

In a world where every choice is an investment, growing up becomes a complex exercise in risk management. The more capital new employees already have when they enter the labor market, the less risky it is for their employers. Over time, firms have an incentive, as the economist Gary Becker put it, to "shift training costs to trainees." If an employer pays to train workers, what's to stop another company from luring them away once they're skilled? The second firm could offer a signing bonus that costs less than the training and still benefit. Paying to train a worker is risky, and risk costs money. As American capitalism advanced, the training burden fell to the state, and then to families and kids themselves.

Childhood risk is less and less about death, illness, or grievous bodily harm and more and more about future prospects. But if it is every parent's task to raise at least one successful American by America's own standards, then the system is rigged so that most of them will fail. The ranks of the American elite are not infinitely expandable; in fact, they're shrinking. Given that reality, parents are told that their children's choices, actions, and accomplishments have lasting consequences. The Harley Avenue letter is merely one of the more dramatic examples of this fearmongering. With parental love as a guide, risk management has become risk elimination.

By looking at children as investments, it's possible to see where the product of children's labor is stored: in their human capital. It's a kid's job to stay eligible for the labor market (and not in jail, insane, or dead). Any work beyond that adds to their résumé. If more human capital automatically led to a higher standard of living, this model could be the foundation for an American meritocracy. But millennials' extra work hasn't earned them the promised higher standard of living. By every metric, this generation is the most educated in American history, yet its members are worse off economically than their parents, grandparents,

and even great-grandparents. Every authority from moms to presidents told millennials to accumulate as much human capital as they could; they did, but the market hasn't held up its end of the bargain. What gives?

As it turns out, just because you can produce an unprecedented amount of value doesn't necessarily mean you can feed yourself under twenty-first-century American capitalism. Kids spend their childhoods investing the only thing they have: their effort, their attention, their days and nights, their labor time. (And, sometimes, a large chunk of whatever money their parents may have.) If the purpose of all this labor, all the lost play, all the hours doing unpleasant tasks, isn't to ensure a good life for the kids doing the work, if it isn't in the "interests of all children," then what is it for?

When you ask most adults what any kid in particular should do with the next part of her life, the advice will generally include pursuing higher education. As the only sanctioned path, college admissions becomes a well-structured, high-stakes simulation of a worker's entry into the labor market. Applicants inventory their achievements, being careful not to underestimate them, and present them in the most attractive package possible.

Then, using the data carefully and anxiously prepared by millions of kids about the human capital they've accumulated over the previous eighteen years, higher education institutions make decisions: collectively evaluating, accepting, and cutting hopeful children in tranches like collateralized debt obligations that are then sorted among the institutions according to their own rankings (for which they compete aggressively, of course). It is not the first time children are weighed, but it is the most comprehensive and often the most directly consequential. College admissions offices are rating agencies. Once the kid-bond is rated, it has four or so years until it's expected to produce a return.

From the November 2017 issue of Harper's Magazine

Harris, Malcolm. 2017. "The Working Classroom." Harper's Magazine, November 2017. harpers.org/archive/2017/11/the-working-classroom

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Childhood in and Through Social Reproduction Theory

Rachel Rosen

Social reproduction refers to the perpetually necessary labour involved in making and sustaining the conditions of life. As I use the concept in this chapter, this includes the processes and practices through which people fulfil embodied needs for themselves and others, and how people are constituted as social beings particular to the time-spaces and social relations they inhabit. This labour¹ which is necessary to maintaining lives is oriented to both immediate and long-term regeneration, just as it is at once physical, mental and affective. It involves activities of repair and maintenance as far ranging as food preparation, cleaning, care for others, as well as childbirth, socialization and subjectification. As such, it can be messy and dirty, as well as involving concern and meaning making, namely ‘the complex ways in which people attempt to make life worth living for themselves and for future generations’ (Narotzky and Besnier 2014). ‘Life’s work’, as Mitchell, Marston and Katz (2003) call it, is paradoxical: existentially necessary yet habitually obscured; indispensable for capital yet always a potential restraint on its profits; often involving acts of love and concern, while also difficult and oppressive. Unsurprisingly then, social reproduction is a slippery concept, diffuse and the subject of debate, not least in the current neoliberal and (neo)colonial conjuncture.

Despite being hyper-present in accounts of social reproduction, childhood remains marginal in its theorization, with children often rendered little more than the objects of reproductive labour and child-rearing treated as one of its more exhausting demands. Despite this, I argue in this chapter that social reproduction is a potent theoretical orientation from which to explore and conceptualize the institution of childhood and the lives of those positioned as children.² In what follows, I expand on the concept of social reproduction, before moving on to identify key debates among its proponents. This enables an exploration of how social reproduction theorizing can be generative for childhood studies and, in turn, how childhood studies might contribute to an expanded conceptual project bringing insights about generation (e.g. adult–child relations) into social reproduction’s analytic frame alongside gender, empire and capital accumulation.

Conceptualizing social reproduction

Both early and contemporary scholarships on social reproduction draw on diverse political and intellectual traditions. The result, argues Lise Vogel (2000), is that the concept has become overly expansive, missing the impetus and trajectory of early theorizing which was to understand the relationship between women's subordination and capital accumulation. In contrast, I suggest that variation and debate can be productive, and my goal here is not to impose consensus or a singular definition of social reproduction. That said, Vogel's argument does highlight that precision as to how concepts are framed and mobilized are important for analytic clarity and political purchase.

Broadly speaking, social reproduction is invoked in one of four ways. The first is a loose or 'conceptually fuzzy' usage, where social reproduction acts as a descriptive synonym for procreation, childbirth, child-rearing, as well as general tasks of familial sustenance. Social reproduction is also used in a Bourdieusian sense, referencing how societies reproduce themselves, with particular focus on the transmission of cultural norms and more broadly social positions and stratifications. Both of these formulations are concerned with generational reproduction; however, neither of these uses of social reproduction is particularly, if at all, concerned with understanding and transforming capitalist social relations.

In contrast, the second set of approaches to social reproduction have their roots in 1970s debates about housework and 'wagelessness' (Mezzadri 2019), and the recognition that capitalism relies on such labour at the same time as treating it as outside circuits of production and therefore remuneration at the household level (Federici 2004; James and Dalla Costa 1972). In posing the question, 'If labour produces the commodity, who produces labour?' (Taha and Salem 2019: 47), theorists question the naturalization of a division between productive and reproductive spheres. They argued that to conceptualize labour as co-terminus with paid work is not only inaccurate, but it represents an acceptance of capital's terms, rendering invisible the labour of social reproduction which offset's capital's costs with deleterious, and often gendered, effects. In contrast, a focus on social reproduction has been viewed as a way to account for, and provide the grounds for challenging, women's subordination under capitalism, such as in the 'Wages for Housework' campaign (Costa and James 1997) or demands for universal childcare (Rosen, Baustad and Edwards 2017).

Among these approaches, and what I am identifying as a third form of social reproductive theorizing, is that of 'dual systems'. Most prominent in early theorizing, dual systems approaches were anti-capitalist but saw their articulation of social reproduction as antithetical to Marxism – a way to address the problems of Marxist theorizing that focused solely on (male) industrial wage earners. Perhaps the best-known dual systems theorist is Christine Delphy (1997) who argued that there was a domestic mode of production, where social reproductive labour was organized via exploitative relations between husbands and wives, alongside a capitalist mode of production. While theorizing the relationship between patriarchy and capitalism remains vexed (Hennessy and Ingraham 1997), dual systems theories are less prevalent in contemporary work on social reproduction. Intellectually, they have been rejected for narrowing women's oppression to unwaged home/family/intimate relations (Molyneux 1979) and indeed naturalizing the historically and spatially specific constitution of public and private spheres (Bhattacharya 2017b); as well as for hiving off struggles for women's liberation from anti-capitalist struggles (Young 1997).

The Bloomsbury Handbook of Theories in Childhood Studies

A final approach can be seen among theorists who saw and continue to see their work on social reproduction as ‘build[ing] from Marx’ (Bhattacharya 2017a: 2). These authors and activists begin from Marx’s insights, and silences, ‘about the circuits producing the most extraordinary commodity of all under capitalism; namely, the worker’ (Mezzadri 2019: 36). Noting that Marx focused primarily on the reproduction of the capitalist system as a whole (what Brenner and Laslett term ‘*societal* reproduction’ [Bhattacharya 2017a]), Marxist feminists have primarily turned their attention to theorizing the *social* reproduction of labour power³ as a core process in the reproduction of capitalism. Labour power, this ‘strange, living commodity’ (Rikowski 2002: 2), is both essential to surplus value production in capitalist societies yet, because of its existential necessity, ‘the capitalist may safely leave this to the worker’s drive for self-preservation and propagation’ (Marx 1976: 718). Despite offering a potent formulation for understanding the articulation of waged and wageless labour, one consequence of Marx’s silences on labour power is that its gendered and racialized (re)production remains naturalized and its subordination to capital essentialized. It is against such problematics that some of the most exciting contemporary theorizing of social reproduction is occurring, as I outline in the following section.

New developments in social reproductive theorizing

Social reproduction theorizing is experiencing something of a renaissance in the context of widening financialization and austerity and the emergence of new forms of inequality and deepening of old (e.g. Bhattacharya 2017b; Taha and Salem 2019; Bhandar 2020; Bakker and Gill 2019). Contemporary theorizing has continued to engage in an animating debate present since the 1970s: Is social reproductive labour productive of surplus value? It has also expanded theorizing: attending to the ways that such labour is stratified in achievement and effect, with a particular focus on the racialized international division of reproductive labour; extending from a focus on housework to a more complex set of sites, forms and actors; and, finally, asserting the dual character of such labour in its relationship to exploitation and resistance. I take each of these points in turn.

Because much of the early theorizing focused on wageless social reproduction, yet aimed to understand this labour’s centrality to capital accumulation, a core question centred on value. More orthodox interpretations continue to suggest that reproductive labour does not produce surplus value in Marx’s specific sense of profit arising in the ‘productive realm’ of commodity production, despite labour power in action being the sole source of this surplus. In contrast, Mezzadri (2019), among others, argues that distinguishing whether labour produces value based on the site it takes place or the type of tasks undertaken, as well as whether it receives payment, is impossible. It is also politically problematic, given the extent of ‘unfree’ and informal labour, as well as subsistence production, in the context of variegated racial capitalisms especially in neo- and settler-colonial contexts. There is, however, no doubt that social reproduction is necessary – for both people and capital – and therefore is central to understanding regimes of accumulation. Regardless of whether it is deemed to be directly or indirectly productive of surplus value, it acts as a subsidy, particularly as capital becomes ‘unmoored’ from place (Katz 2002), making it easier to evade responsible for supporting social reproduction (e.g. through payment of corporate tax, as evidenced by the widespread use of offshore tax havens revealed in the Pandora Papers) or by externalizing the costs of social reproduction through the use of internal or international

migrant labour largely reproduced elsewhere. Nancy Fraser (2016), for example, argues that expropriation (where ‘unfree’ subjects are the source of profit through ‘confiscation’ of land, labour, and human beings themselves) is just as central, and entangled with, exploitation (where formally free workers generate profit through wage labour) for contemporary accumulation.

This debate has significant political consequences, namely if and how social reproduction figures in anti-capitalist movements. It is here that theorists and activists are insistent that the necessity of labour power for capital highlights the limits of the archetypical adult industrial worker cum revolutionary subject and makes social reproduction a crucial site of struggle. For critical childhood studies, as I will go on to discuss, it offers a generative way to situate and analyse the positioning and subordination of children beyond the realm of waged work (Spyrou, Rosen and Cook 2019).

As I have hinted earlier, much early theorizing of social reproduction focused on women and their social reproductive labour in the home. This provided important insights about its gendered effects, but more recent work addresses the problematic homogenization of women in some theorizing. Newer work has stressed the ways in which slavery, colonialism and systemic racism shape the achievement of social reproduction and stratify its effects (Taha and Salem 2019), such as the hyper-exploitation of minoritized and migrant domestic workers in the ‘Global North’ and the progressively devalued care work left in the wake of this global care chain (Colen 1995; Rosen, Baustad and Edwards 2017; Parrenas 2012). Others stress that rather than sustaining lives, class relations mean that for impoverished families, existentially necessary reproductive labour can effectively ‘deplete’ or ‘exhaust’, rather than regenerate, in the effort of survival (Rai, Hoskyns and Thomas 2013; Dowling 2016).

As mention of domestic workers suggests, another key development has been the effort to extend the focus from familial-based housework to a more complex set of sites, forms and actors. In part this reflects points made earlier about the impossibility of precisely separating productive and reproductive spheres, particularly given the rise of new forms of home working and dormitory-based labour (Mezzadri 2020). Since the rise of neoliberalism in the 1970s, social reproductive labour itself has been increasingly commodified and a site of profit in the ‘productive’ realm. The rapid expansion of multi-national childcare companies, outsourcing of social work and rising use of private detention companies in immigration and youth justice systems are but a few examples. Among the implications for contemporary social reproduction theorizing is the importance of considering the interplay and boundary making around who bears responsibility for reproductive labour (be this families, capital or the local/national/international state) and to whom the benefits accrue, as well as theories that can account for both unwaged social reproductive labour *and* its provision through commodification, not least through the unfree and low-waged labour of people racialized as ‘Other’ in domestic settings.

A final, but related point, lies in the way that the family is conceptualized in relation to social reproduction. Feminists working with critical race theory’ for instance, provide a trenchant critique of theories of social reproduction which reduce the family to a site of oppression and exploitation of women. They point out that social reproductive labour within minoritized families can bolster resilience and collective resistance in racist societies (Bhandar 2020). As Federici (2012) notes, social reproductive labour has a dual character. It is both central to accumulation in that it reproduces workers for capital but equally it can be a labour of love, reciprocity and world-making labour where opposition to subordination and injustice may be fomented (Rosen and Newberry 2018).

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Childhood and social reproduction theory

Social reproduction theorists have made crucial advances in making visible socially necessary labour which is obscured by binary constructions of divided public–private or productive–reproductive realms. However, it has remained largely blinkered when it comes to children and childhood, in part because children rarely feature as protagonists or the figure through which social reproduction is theorized. Children do appear centrally in theorizing about social reproductive labour, in so far as childbirth and the physical, practical, emotional and moral dimensions involved in ensuring children’s sustenance and socialization ‘as future agents of production’ is often treated as the most exhaustive aspect of reproductive labour or ‘most entrapping material relation for women’ (Molyneux 1979: 25). The explosion in scholarship on ‘intensive motherhood’ or ‘intensive parenting’, while not necessarily framed in terms of reproductive labour, is among the latest iteration of this argument. In these formulations, where children themselves are the focus, it is typically in terms of the labour and resources required for sustaining them until they can do so themselves, an understanding of ‘child as futurity’ as the previous quote suggests rather than a view of children as participants in the labour of social reproduction.

Despite these erasures, scholars in childhood studies have made creative analytic use of social reproduction theory, and, as I go on to argue, it can be a productive frame for thinking with. At the same time, this childhood studies scholarship is helping to expand social reproduction theory through attention to childhoods, real and imagined. In what follows, I elaborate on three areas where such generative synergies exist: children’s involvement in reproductive labour, the explanatory power of social reproduction in relation to the subordination of children as a social group and the fissures in accumulation through social reproduction that the child figure lays bare.

Children’s involvement in reproductive labour

Perhaps one of the biggest contributions childhood studies has made is the insistence that children are active human agents. Their social activity has been described and explored in a multitude of contexts; however, with notable exceptions, this has been less thoroughly theorized. Where it has been given conceptual grounding, this has primarily been in terms of social and political agency, typically grounded – whether implicitly or explicitly – in a sovereign subject, a frame roundly critiqued for its liberal assumptions (Balagopalan 2019) and circular, self-fulfilling claims (Spyrou, Rosen and Cook 2019).

Social reproduction theory offers a different, and productive, way of understanding some of this activity. Scholars have documented the ways that children, in a wide variety of contexts, are involved in a myriad of everyday activities necessary for the repair and maintenance of self and others. Children shop for household items, cook and serve food; sweep, clean and do laundry; run errands for the household, collect and prepare heating and cooking fuel; tend kitchen gardens and manage household animals; and more (e.g. Abebe 2016; Katz 2004; Magazine and Sánchez 2007; Nieuwenhuys 2020).

Children are often expected to, and do, provide care for others, often those who are younger than themselves. However, emotional, physical and practical care includes, but is not limited to, ‘childcare’. For instance, my own research explores the ways in which young, unaccompanied children on the move care for others on migration journeys and while they are seeking regularization in the United Kingdom. Some will cook and ensure that those newly arrived

have a warm and welcoming meal. Others provide advice, helping newly arrived young people understand how to navigate the restrictive migration regime, including who to avoid and who might help. Some translate, helping other young people to engage with social workers, teachers and medical staff – those who are legally expected to care but cannot or do not – and hold them to account (Rosen 2023).

By closely attending to young people's lives, researchers have documented with fine-grained detail the complex ways that children are able to read the feelings of those around them and provide emotional support. In some cases, their everyday, but certainly not banal, practices make life bearable in impossible circumstances and their care gives life meaning. A core idea emerging out of this literature is that children practice a form of reflexivity, engaging in practices of care around identity work that enable the adults in their lives to feel that, despite conditions of hardship, they *are* 'good parents'. In the research of Vergara del Solar, Sepúlveda Galeas, and Salvo Agoglia (2020), this emerges as Chilean children perform and display a sense of living a happy and protected childhood thanks to their parents, despite the overwhelming and unrepayable debt the family is burdened with. On the other side of the world, Hinton (2000: 207) shows how young children in refugee camps in Nepal engaged in acts of reflexive care, such as one 5-year-old who would ask to nurse, which allowed mothers to take up 'a role that [they felt] provided social value and unique utility' in contrast to the pathologizing atmosphere of the camp and individualized mental health interventions.

Children's reproductive labour is often undertaken alongside parents (primarily mothers, given gendered divisions of labour) (Llobet and Milanich 2018). It can be understood both as part of long traditions of children's participation in reproductive labour and as a dynamic response to changing political economic conditions. It has been conceptualized as a way of coping with shocks or crises (Bourdillon, Crivello and Pankhurst 2015) which remove parents from their regenerative and sustenance activities for the household because of illness or death (Haley and Bradbury 2015). It also may result from family migration projects (Parrenas 2005) and 'development' initiatives, such as micro-financing (Hazarika and Sarangi 2008), where children take up labour that their mothers had done previously. It can also occur in the context of limited and retrenched state support and public services. For instance, in my ongoing research with Eve Dickson about families who are denied mainstream welfare benefits in the UK due to their immigration status, when mothers end up taking on under-the-table work or flexible shift-work due to their precarious immigration status, children often take up significant reproductive labour for their family.

Recent theorizing which refuses the relegation of social reproduction labour to the household opens up the possibility of considering children's activity in non-domestic arenas. As Jan Newberry and I (Newberry and Rosen 2020) have argued elsewhere, to do otherwise, 'obscures the reproductive labor undertaken by children in educational institutions'. There, children labour upon themselves, enhancing their labour power with skills, knowledge, dispositions and so forth. Although this labour power may never be actualized in use, its 'quality enhancement' is a central strategy for increasing relative surplus value in contemporary capitalism (Rikowski 2003). The labour children undertake in such settings remains largely invisible *as labour*. Indeed, their efforts in educational settings are often counterposed to 'child labour' and given normative weight as being and assuring a 'good childhood' – regardless of the conditions in which schooling occurs and its centrality to extractive process (Rosen 2019), or the ways in which 'child labor laws

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condemn de facto children to unpaid domestic work or work on the family's land or enterprise' (Nieuwenhuys 2020: 130).

Making visible the various ways that children are involved in the reproduction of labour power provides an important corrective to accounts which ignore such activity. But it also challenges the idea that children's participation in reproductive labour is exceptional, something that only happens in conditions of precarity, hardship, and survival in informal economies or times of 'shock' (Abebe 2016). To be sure, crises conditions and wider political economic change prompts shifts in children's activities and its short- and long-term importance to families. Certainly, the labour of reproduction is not equally distributed nor as easily achieved in conditions of precarity (as I discuss further below). The point I want to make here is that while reproductive labour shifts in time and place, children globally (like adults) can and do participate in the reciprocal, interdependent and intergenerational practices of sustaining and maintaining life (Rosen and Newberry 2018; Magazine and Sánchez 2007).

In short, social reproduction theory, in combination with insights from childhood studies, provides a framework for attending to children's participation in creative, world-making acts involved in the labour of making lives. More, it prompts consideration of linkages with practices and 'public issues' (Mills 1970), a way to interrogate how children's everyday practices are joined up with wider processes of capital accumulation, exploitation and expropriation.

Stratified social reproduction and the subordination of children

As I have already suggested, reproductive labour is not equally distributed globally or intersectionally. In this section, I discuss the stratification of reproductive labour in more detail, showing how the interface of social reproduction theory and insights from childhood studies offer explanatory power for understanding how generational and other unequal social relations are reproduced.

The first point to make in this regard is that children's reproductive labour is often rendered invisible. In some instances, this happens through a paternalistic framing where, regardless of the nature of the labour or its quality, it is reduced to socialization, learning or help. When viewed through such a lens, nothing children ever do can be considered reproductive labour for the simple fact that they are children; and, by corollary, this implies that the necessary labour is actually undertaken by the adult(s) who guide, lead and teach it. My point is not to dismiss processes of learning that occur throughout the life course, including in relation to reproductive labour. Instead, I am suggesting it is more helpful, analytically and politically, to understand this as a reciprocal and intergenerational process (Abebe 2016; Rosen and Newberry 2018), keeping open questions as to learning that may happen whether because someone is new to the task or new to the technologies and resources involved in completing such tasks. For instance, in my ongoing research with Eve Dickson about families in precarious migrancy, household responsibilities are divided up via complex negotiations of the skills, knowledges and time each family member has available, as well as gendered and generational assumptions about tasks and responsibilities. To give a specific example, in one family involved in the research, the oldest child communicates with social workers and advocates in the third sector due to their greater experience with online technologies and English-language proficiency, while the mother views cooking as a difficult skill, and one that requires her expertise or training.

As scholars of gender have pointed out, reproductive labour is highly gendered, often treated discursively and practically as something that women do 'naturally'. Following McDowell (1986),

the potential ability to give birth to children is over-extended to all those positioned as women and to all other reproductive activities. This discursive leap both links women and children to each other and naturalizes their role in carrying out reproductive labour. At the same time, the reliance of infants on others for their basic survival has been over-extended to all children, ‘overwriting children’s potential capabilities with social ascriptions of vulnerability, need and dependency’ (Rosen and Newberry 2018: 126), and rendering their contributions opaque or as unskilled initiation in the world.

The erasure of children’s reproductive labour is reinforced by their ‘protected’ legal status. Here, efforts to safeguard children based on assumptions that work is a ‘hostile world’ and that ‘marketplace logic destroys virtuous childhood’ (Zelizer 2005: 186) leads to ‘ever-energetic efforts to ban the paid work of children’ (Nieuwenhuys 2020: 130). This serves to lower children’s status and ability to protect themselves from the ravages of neoliberal capitalism in two ways. First, children continue to engage in reproductive labour in a wageless capacity – such as in the domestic realm, family enterprises or small land holdings, in schools through the reproduction of labour power, and so forth. However, their potential exploitation in these fields often goes unrecognized in discourses focused on banning child labour and their potential to organize for better working conditions is diminished. Further, in monetized economies, not being able to undertake waged labour renders children dependent on others, typically adults, regardless of their continuing unwaged reproductive labour. This ‘temporal lag’ between labour needed for reproduction, which reduces the possibilities for engagement wage labour in the short-term, is key to understanding both children’s entanglements with capital, regardless of whether they directly engage with the ‘marketplace’, and their generational subordination (Rosen and Newberry 2018; Newberry and Rosen 2020).

For those children who work for wages as a way of sustaining family life, generational subordination remains, however. For instance, Glockner (2023), in her study of working children in India and Mexico, points out that children’s informal labour in a wage economy often is motivated by concern and care for their family’s survival, particularly those shouldering extensive debt. Here, not only are the analytic boundaries between reproductive and productive labour exposed for their porous and constructed nature, but children’s legal status as dependents means that their financial and emotional care for adult family members becomes a source of their subordination. Her point is that children, thus, take on great responsibility but their subordinate status is self-reinforcing: parents control how wages are used and distributed within generational social orders and capital makes use of reciprocal care as a motivation for wage labour, benefiting from children’s low social status and therefore their cheapened labour.

Stratified social reproduction is not simply a question of children’s subordination, however, but an intersectional one. In this regard Nieuwenhuys (2020: 131) offers up the concept of the ‘global womb’: ‘a metaphor for the largely invisible socioeconomic spaces inhabited by a majority of women and children’ in the Global South. In using this metaphor, she urges attention to Southern children’s extensive engagement in reproductive labour as well as the South’s role more broadly ‘producing abundant life for free, to provision the North’ (Nieuwenhuys 2020: 132). This is a generative metaphor that extends theorizing of variegated social reproduction, demonstrating that the ways in which different children are positioned and involved in the labour of reproducing life cannot be separated from geopolitical inequities. It also serves as a helpful reminder that while the schooled child may be the idealized figure in globally hegemonic terms (Newberry and

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Rosen 2020; Rosen 2019), it certainly does not account for the materiality of existence, and the diverse and stratified ways in which children globally are involved in making lives.

That said, framing the stratification of reproductive labour in terms of a North–South binary seems less fruitful than a ‘connected’ (Bhambra 2014) or ‘counter-topographical’ (Katz 2001) approach. These latter propositions focus on the way that processes (such as the reproduction of labour power) are linked, differentiated and hierarchically ordered in intersectional ways given marginalization in the North as well as the South. They also avoid the problematic of reifying the North and South as separate and distinct entities, given the mobility of capital, goods and people in an ‘always-already’ global age (Bhambra 2014). In so doing, (neo and settler) colonialism and chattel slavery are seen as pivotal to capitalism rather than merely its happenstance companions, providing ways to understand the class, raced and gendered ways in which support for social reproduction, whether through welfare provisions, religious institutions or, otherwise, is structured and knitted together globally.

These points about the global and intersectional stratification of reproductive labour can be given flesh through consideration of the experiences of unaccompanied young people, those on the move without parents or guardians. Upon arriving in the UK, these young people are met by a ‘hostile immigration’ regime and a popular discourse which vacillates between one of hospitality, because they are lone children, and nativist exclusion because they are viewed as a ‘burden’, taking away from local children (Rosen and Crafter 2018) – a reflection of the myth of the UK’s welfare state as national project, rather than one resourced through colonial empire, chattel slavery and their afterlife (El-Enany 2020). This contradiction leaves unaccompanied young people in the difficult position of being in the care of the local state as their ‘corporate parents’ at the same time as being disproportionately placed in (semi)independent provision (Greatbatch and Tate 2020). This is an outsourced and unregulated form of accommodation and support hours, allowable in law when children are deemed to no longer need care.

In this case, the law effectively means these young people must engage in social reproductive labour largely on their own, reflective of racialization ideas about childhood and who is deserving of care. This outsourced and privatized aspect of children’s services is part of a larger process of neoliberalization and austerity-based retrenchment (Jones 2019), where responsabilization for care and social support is increasingly being put on to individuals and families. Accomplishing reproductive labour is therefore highly stratified – much more difficult to accomplish in the context of limited resources, legal restrictions on work (whether because of generational or immigration status) and precarious labour rights. Unaccompanied young people fill gaps in state support by cooking for themselves and others, cleaning and maintaining the shared properties where they are placed, as private providers limit services, providing advice and support to newly arrived young people about how to navigate the system. But unaccompanied young people also are called upon by private providers to support reproductive tasks the companies have been paid to deliver, such as through translation and accompaniment for other young people in the accommodation (Rosen 2021, 2023). Yet, in a context of limited resources, precarious status and limited avenues for exercising rights, social reproductive labour is a constrained and difficult achievement, and may lead to further marginalization and inequalities in outcomes (Rosen, Crafter and Meetoo 2021).

Unaccompanied young people therefore subsidize capital through reproductive labour for themselves and their friends, and subsidize those private companies which are benefiting from the commodification of reproductive labour in a neoliberal era. But this is missed, even in critical left

theorizing of social reproduction, if children are treated simply as the objects of such labour rather than its protagonists. This reproduces generational injustices and limits the scope for addressing extractivism and exploitation. In contrast, I have suggested that theorizing social reproduction through the figure of the child opens up the possibility for considering the centrality of children and young people to stratified social reproduction and capital accumulation. It also helps to account for the ways that generational antagonisms, such as those between adults and children in formulations of the pressures of intensive parenting, and others are constituted, at least in part, through ‘their (uneven and situated) productivity for capital’ (Rosen and Newberry 2018: 131).

Reproductive labour beyond extraction

A critically important point stemming from the understanding of social reproduction that I have been developing lies in the dual nature of labour power: while it may be necessary for capital, as the source of surplus value, it is not exhausted by capital. Repair and maintenance of fragile human bodies, as well as the making of subjects and social relations, may be profoundly shaped by processes which facilitate domination and extraction, but they are not determined by them. It is in this regard that Black feminist scholars, in particular, have insisted that reproductive labour in the home cannot simply be understood in terms of oppression, but as spaces where resistance might be fostered and non-capitalist ways of being nurtured. For childhood studies, such insights offer fruitful avenues to reflect on the temporal-spatial dimensions of children’s relation to capital and, in turn, to theorize social transformation and activism beyond the categories of (liberal) capitalism.

While children may be born and raised within capitalist societies, ‘their bodies and minds must learn their way into those capitalist subjectivities’ (Ferguson 2017: 114). In other words, no one begins life as a capitalist subject, and therefore the newness of children’s lives sets them at a temporal distance from capital’s incursions. Further, Ferguson (2017: 121) argues, the legal and moral separation of children from direct exploitation in wage labour – through anti-child-labour laws for instance – creates a ‘spatial and temporal distance from the direct labor/capital relation’ allowing ‘the foregrounding of other (sensuous, creative) dimensions of human activity to flourish’. This assertion neglects the heterogeneity of children’s lives, not least because children do engage in waged labour albeit in globally unequal ways and, as I have already outlined, participate in reproductive labour from a very early age, representing at very least indirect forms of surplus value generation for capital. Notwithstanding these stipulations, in keeping with Mannheim’s articulation of generation and generational change (Alanen 2011), this provides a useful approach to conceptualizing the way that practices and subjectivities which exceed or transform capitalist social relations may emerge in the time-spaces of generational and other forms of marginality.

In foregrounding creative practices of world-making, imaginative play has been proposed as an important site where children’s social reproduction activity takes place. In part, this relates to the conflation of play and childhood, but it also speaks to the characteristics of play as a liminal space where marginalized child subjects (as well as adults) may explore, experience and forge alternatives. While I am resistant to treatments of play as a space free from capital – not least because it is a mode of expression subject to intensive marketing, control and surveillance; it is embedded within contexts of great inequity and can amplify injurious social relations; and because of resonances with the idealized subject of neoliberalism who is playful, creative and flexible – I am nonetheless compelled by the potentials of play and imagination. As Katz (2004: 253) argues, having ‘a vision of what else could be’ is central to any radical politics. Imaginative play allows for

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just this as it is both contestive and subjunctive: to play is to pull apart the world and build it anew in the spirit of ‘what if’ or ‘as if’ (Henricks 2006). In imaginative play, it becomes possible, albeit without guarantee, to refuse accepted meanings, create new and more expansive understandings of value, experiment with ways of being and overturn the status quo, at very least within the confines of play (Rosen 2017). It is for these reasons that childhood scholars have turned to imaginative play as a site where children reproduce themselves for and *beyond* capital.

Another way of thinking about how capital constrains social reproduction, but does not exhaust its possibilities, lies in the social reproductive practices of care and mutual aid between unaccompanied young people which I have hinted about earlier. In the Children Caring on the Move research project (Rosen 2023), we heard about the ways that young people share resources even when they themselves are struggling. Stories of meals of welcome offered by young people who were strangers just days before animate our field notes. Narratives of hope and connection forged between young people across seemingly insurmountable divides of language, nationality, gender and more provide glimpses of the ways in which geopolitical borders and social boundaries are exposed for their fabrication and violence, and alternative ways of being are enacted. The generous acts we have witnessed among young people challenge neoliberal assumptions of care as motivated by private interests and justified through cost-benefit rationalities. Instead, they suggest the power and potentialities of a relationality motivated by concern for collective wellbeing. While fleeting and fragile, the moments when young people’s practices challenge injustices of the present and nurture affective, embodied and material ways of being otherwise provide a sense of alternative futures in action, or reproductive labour in and *beyond* capital.

Looking afresh at social reproduction through the lens of childhood, play and care is important not simply because it refutes a functionalist view of labour power. Considering social reproduction through the figure of the child offers glimpses of capital’s fragility, of the spaces which it fails to conquer or the places where its weaknesses might lie. This offers an important political corrective to the enduring figure of the male industrial worker as the revolutionary subject par excellence, wage labour as the primary site of struggle or the rational speaking subject as the foundational political subject. Instead, the dual nature of labour power indicates what is at stake in questions about social reproduction theory and why it is the subject of intense political struggle over responsibility for fulfilling collective needs. Attending to childhood in this regard offers new ways to theorize political struggle beyond the categories of (liberal) capitalism which often shape categories of analysis and political action. Elsewhere, I have suggested that play may provide an intergenerational space that destabilizes adult–child power relations offering opportunities to engage and create embodied and affective understandings of what matters or comes to matter collectively, imagine the sorts of worlds we might want to live in and grapple with complex ethical-political conundrums (Rosen 2017). Likewise, the care and reciprocity I have witnessed in the shared labour of social reproduction undertaken by unaccompanied young people pulls into relief insights into the conditions which nourish solidarities or projects of common cause, sometimes in the spaces where they are least expected and most difficult to ensure (Rosen 2023).

Conclusion

In this chapter, I have explored the synergies between social reproduction theory and childhood studies. Notwithstanding the silences and occasionally awkward ways these bodies of work speak to each other (Rosen and Newberry 2018), I have highlighted the mutual productivities

of this encounter. On the one hand, by offering a potent analytic framework to contextualize the institution of childhood and adult–child power relations within a critique of contemporary capitalisms, social reproduction theory addresses a spectre that haunts childhood studies: the radical decontextualization of childhood through forms of child exceptionalism. On the other hand, interrogating social reproduction through the child figure surfaces aspects of reproductive labour that are often erased, and therefore which inadvertently reproduce the separation of public and private, adult and child, imagination and activism. Together they offer potent insights for the study of the intergenerational labour of making meaning lives but also to contest the unjust conditions in which this labour accomplished.

Notes

- 1 Labour is understood here as creative and practical act with world-making possibility and is used interchangeably with ‘work’. I am bypassing debates distinguishing between work and labour, for example, the articulation of labour as a particular form of work embedded in capitalist social relations (Bakker and Gill 2019) or a critique of the problematic moralism in contemporary charity campaigning and institutional discourse in invocations of ‘child labour’.
- 2 By way of some ground clearing, I should note that I understood ‘childhood’ as part of a socially constructed social relation within generational social orders (Alanen 2011). As such, when I use the term ‘child/children’, I do not call up a category of people who fit within an immutable list of essential characteristics. Instead, I refer to a social position and the situated and historically dynamic processes whereby certain human beings are made into children, inclusive of the ways it interpellates subjects and is performed, imposed, contested and transformed.
- 3 Labour power is ‘the aggregate of those mental and physical capabilities existing in a human being, which he [*sic*] exercises whenever he produces a use-value of any description’ (Marx 1977 [1867]: 164). Labour power capabilities include not only embodied capacities, skills and knowledges but also modes of being including those which are required for specific types of labour (e.g. creativity and flexibility in a gig economy). These capabilities also have a more generalised form which Rikowski (2000) refers to as ‘labour power willingness’: dispositions, beliefs and desires which at a most basic level can be understood as part of the capitalist subjectivities required for participation in wage labour for subsistence in monetized economies. Labour power has a virtual existence – embodied as a potential in each person – and a real social existence which is activated when labour power is put into action – regardless of whether this relates to use or exchange value. As such, labour power potentials are greater than their actuation and their creative, world-making potentials far exceed any productivist notions of labour (Jaffe 2021).

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